



Vishal Seth is the World Cyber Games 2004 (India) champion in FIFA 2004

Apparently, she had developed a habit of playing computer games at her friend's place. Naturally, her parents complained that her studies were being hampered. They desperately sought measures to stop this "menace," which was keeping their daughter awake night after night.

Dr Nirmala Rao of Aavishkar, a self-development centre in Mumbai, shares two cases. Zeeshan (name changed) was brought to her by his father—a doctor. Zeeshan had been frequenting cyber-café since standard XI. Initially it wasn't a problem, but by standard XII, he was spending too much time on the computer, playing games.

Sensing an addiction, his father arranged for Rs 45,000 and asked his son to buy himself a PC. However, one day he found that there was only Rs 10,000 left.

The boy had gone to the extent of spending the money, in unspecified ways, in order to be able to participate in a gaming competition. A representative of the official sponsors of the competition, when contacted, said that there were no registration fees involved; so the money was probably spent in practising over LANs in cyber-café.

"Competitiveness turns children into addicts. It's an easy addiction, like gambling," says Dr Rao.



In a game, you are the master... Routine life is boring

Dr Nirmala Rao
Psychiatrist

The Lotus-eater

In another twist, an eight-year-old girl complained that her mother stationed herself in front of the computer the moment she returned home from work. In a family of working parents, the kid was on her own most of the time, and craved for some attention in the evenings—which her mother failed to satisfy.

This slowly drove her to depression. The mother complained that her bank job tired her, and that the PC—including the games on it—helped her unwind.

Vishal Seth, a member of Team Acid from Pune, which won the Counter Strike tournament at the WCG (World Cyber Games), admits that games are addictive. But he insists it's a hobby, and he will be able to give it up. Reginald Miranda from Delhi says he gives himself seven out of 10 in terms of level of patience.

"I used to play eight to 10 hours a day before joining work." He says that that is now down to about four hours. He still plays on weekends, though. Rahul Rohira, also a member of Team

Acid, and Varun Srinivasan of The International School, Bangalore (TISB)—both avid gamers—are silent about how patient they are!

With the exception of Varun, the night is the time for all gamers. Known as Cybervarun in the Massively Multiplayer Online Role Playing Game (MMORPG) Ragnarok, he spends 12 to 24 hours a week playing over a network. Cyber-café being closed or inaccessible, he does not play at night.

Most gamers insist their parents have no problems with their gaming habits. They all do miss dinner at home though.

The Power

"People always look for stimulation," says Dr Rao. "Excitement, sensation! Computer games give them that. In a game, you are the master, have control and can get a lot of adrenaline rush. Routine life is boring."

She says that gamers are addicted to the "power" that games offer over a PC, the kind of which they can not wield over people in their age group in real life. They therefore prefer a computer over people, thereby shunning social life.

It is regularly found that young kids who take up a game, speedily graduate to a higher level of skill. Young and tech-savvy people pick up things faster since the brain is fresh and reacts faster. Another possible reason, Dr Rao says, is that they have to be quick, else they lose points.

Dr Choksi agrees. He suggests a virtual feeling of satisfaction as the reason for such craving. Citing the example of chess, he says it challenges the intellect, but it does not allow for interaction with another individual, the kind that is there to be had in virtual games.

He says, "It is screen fascination. It gives you a false sense of mastery, a personality in a virtual world." He does say, though, "Computer games are not bad, as long as there is no addiction."

This myth of success at the virtual level being an impetus to addiction is hard to believe. Most gamers came across as fairly successful, normal people. True, the adrenaline rushes while they are playing, but none admit to delusions or an

Reality check

Can you answer the following questions?

- 1 When was Bill Gates born?
- 2 Do you read books? Who is the author of
 - a. Asterix comics
 - b. Calvin and Hobbes
 - c. War and Peace
 - d. Hitchhiker's guide to the Galaxy
- 3 Who is John Romero?
- 4 Who is the current deputy PM of India?

Only Miranda got most of them right. The others got a maximum of 2 or 3 correct. However, they all have their favourite cartoons and favourite music. They surf the Net, and are not averse to watching TV.

Answers:
1 Oct. 28, 1955
2 a. Goswami and Udayar
b. Bill Watterson
c. Leo Tolstoy
d. Douglas Adams
3 One of the designers of Doom and Quake, and also of classic games such as Wolf 3D
4 No one! We don't have a deputy PM

